



NANCY BELANGER, 65, clears a clogged drain in front of a burned home in Pacific Palisades. She lost one house, but another survived.

GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

Biggest storm of year slams L.A.

Atmospheric river prompts mandatory evacuations for some in high-risk areas.

BY RONG-GONG LIN II, NATHAN SOLIS, HANNAH FRY AND CLARA HARTER

The biggest rainstorm of the season slammed into Southern California on Thursday, bringing with it flash floods, severe thunderstorms and the possibility of “life-threatening” debris flows just a month after fierce Santa Ana winds propelled a firestorm across L.A. County.

The National Weather Service issued flash flood and thunderstorm warnings for a wide swath of the county, with rainfall rates of 0.75 inches to 1.25 inches per hour expected. Debris flows may be triggered when rainfall rates exceed 0.5 inches per hour. Burn scars in the Palisades, Franklin and Eaton fires pose a strong danger of slides.

“There is now a high risk for a life-threatening debris flow,” the weather service said. “Mud, rock, and debris flows will have the potential to impact drainages, roads, and residences in and directly below the burn area.”

Areas covered by flash flood warnings Thursday afternoon and evening included a wide swath of Los Angeles County, including

Edison knew that cutting power was fire risk

Records show utility was told in 2022 that emergency shutdown could overload lines.

BY CONNOR SHEETS

On Jan. 7, as fierce winds whipped across the foothills of the San Gabriel Mountains, residents frantically called Southern California Edison, imploring the utility to turn off power around Altadena to keep electrical equipment from sparking a wildfire.

Minutes after 6 p.m., witnesses

spotted a fire under an Edison transmission tower in Eaton Canyon. Since then, there has been intense scrutiny from both investigators and experts about whether that tower ignited a fire that destroyed more than 9,000 structures and killed 17 people.

While the exact cause remains under investigation, Edison has acknowledged that evidence suggests its equipment may have played a role. The company previously revealed that its lines over Eaton Canyon saw a momentary increase of electrical current about the same time as the fire began.

What hasn’t yet been fully explained is why the utility delayed shutting off power to much of the area — and whether it could have done more to prevent the catastrophe.

But public records uncovered by The Times indicate the company had been warned less than three years ago about the risk that a power shutdown would overload other transmission lines, potentially causing dangerous overheating and sparks. Fixes that some experts said could have mitigated the risk were repeatedly delayed, the records [See Shutdown, A6]



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

INVESTIGATORS view the area seen as the possible origin of the Eaton fire in Eaton Canyon in Altadena.

Trump ups ante, rolls out reciprocal tariff plan

BY JOSH BOAK

WASHINGTON — President Trump on Thursday rolled out his plan to increase U.S. tariffs to match the tax rates that other countries charge on imports, possibly triggering a broader economic confrontation with allies and rivals alike, as Trump says he aims to eliminate any trade imbalances.

“I’ve decided for purposes of fairness that I will charge a reciprocal tariff,” Trump said in the Oval Office at the proclamation signing. “It’s fair to all. No other country can complain.”

Trump’s administration has said that its new tariffs would level the playing field between U.S. manufacturers and foreign competitors, though these new taxes probably would be paid by American consumers and businesses either directly or in the form of higher prices.

The politics of tariffs could easily backfire on Trump if his agenda pushes up inflation and grinds down growth, making this a high-stakes wager for a president. [See Tariffs, A8]



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

TEDDY VAZQUEZ, owner of Teddy’s Red Tacos, says sales are down by half after President Trump announced executive actions targeting illegal immigrants.

Immigration enforcement rattles L.A.’s dining scene

Restaurant workers, patrons are afraid to lead normal lives with expected ICE raids.

BY CINDY CARCAMO

The chilly first two months of the year are usually a peak business period for Teddy’s Red Tacos, where diners indulge in the restaurant’s specialty, birria — spicy, warm and deeply tender meat slowly braised in its own fat and served with

a pool of flavorful broth.

But this year, it’s different.

The day after President Trump announced a series of immigration actions to fulfill a campaign promise of mass deportations, Teddy Vazquez, owner of Teddy’s Red Tacos, noticed a steep drop in sales at all of his 10 locations in Los Angeles and Orange counties.

Two weeks later, sales had dropped by half of what he’d normally make in January.

“People are afraid to go out. There’s no movement.

There are no people coming in to eat,” Vazquez said. “People don’t want to go out because they don’t know what is going to happen with this administration.”

Vazquez said most of his taco shops — from Echo Park to Anaheim — are in neighborhoods with a large proportion of immigrant inhabitants.

“A lot of people who support Teddy’s are immigrants,” he said. “Customers are thinking: ‘What if [Immigration and Customs Enforcement] shows up while

Kennedy confirmed as health secretary

Vaccine skeptic who has advanced false theories wins over Republican senators.

BY AMANDA SEITZ

WASHINGTON — The Senate on Thursday confirmed Robert F. Kennedy Jr. and he was then sworn in as President Trump’s health secretary, putting the prominent vaccine skeptic in control of \$1.7 trillion in federal spending, vaccine recommendations and food safety as well as health insurance programs for roughly half the country.

Nearly all Republicans fell in line behind Trump’s nominee despite hesitancy

over Kennedy’s views on vaccines as the Senate voted 52 to 48 to elevate the scion of one of America’s most storied political — and Democratic — families to secretary of the Health and Human Services Department. Democrats unanimously opposed Kennedy.

Kentucky Sen. Mitch McConnell, who had polio as a child, was the only no vote among Republicans, mirroring his stands against Trump’s picks for the Pentagon chief and director of national intelligence.

“I’m a survivor of childhood polio. In my lifetime, I’ve watched vaccines save millions of lives from devastating diseases across America and around the world,” McConnell said in a

[See Kennedy, A8]

Trump cedes to Russia on Ukraine

As Putin is granted his wish to end war, Kyiv and Europe voice anger at being sidelined. **WORLD, A3**

UCLA suspends protest groups

Students for Justice in Palestine organizations rallied at UC regent’s home. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Showers around. L.A. Basin: 64/46. **B6**

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Captain America has work cut out

Marvel and Disney have a lot riding on the hero’s new movie, a reintroduction. **BUSINESS, A9**

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